15.5.1 Policy coverage

The first dimension was the breadth of systems using PBAC. As more applications, APIs, and internal tools adopted policy engines and began evaluating requests against foundational, shared operational, and application-specific rules, ACME could enforce consistent requirements across more of its environment. Growth in policy coverage indicated that Zero Trust was penetrating deeper into the organization's systems.

In practice, ACME measured policy coverage by tracking which systems made authorization decisions through a policy engine and which still relied on embedded or ad hoc logic. The security and platform teams maintained an inventory of services and tools, noting whether each one enforced access using PBAC, partially delegated authorization to policy, or bypassed policy entirely. This inventory was reviewed regularly and used to identify gaps.

For example, early in the transition, ACME discovered that while most customer-facing services evaluated requests through a policy engine, several internal administrative tools still relied on hard-coded role checks and network-based trust. By migrating those tools to use the same foundational and shared operational policies as other systems, ACME significantly increased policy coverage without rewriting business logic. Over time, the percentage of access decisions evaluated by a policy engine became a leading indicator of Zero Trust adoption.

15.5.2 Signal quality

High-quality signals were equally important. Device posture, authentication freshness, principal attributes, and operational context needed to be accurate, timely, and governed. If these inputs were incomplete, stale, or inconsistent, even well-written policies could produce unreliable decisions.

ACME assessed signal quality by checking if data feeding its policy engine met defined expectations for freshness, completeness, and consistency. For each major signal type, the security and identity teams defined service-level indicators: how recently the signal was updated, how often it was missing when needed, and whether it followed agreed-upon schemas. Signals that